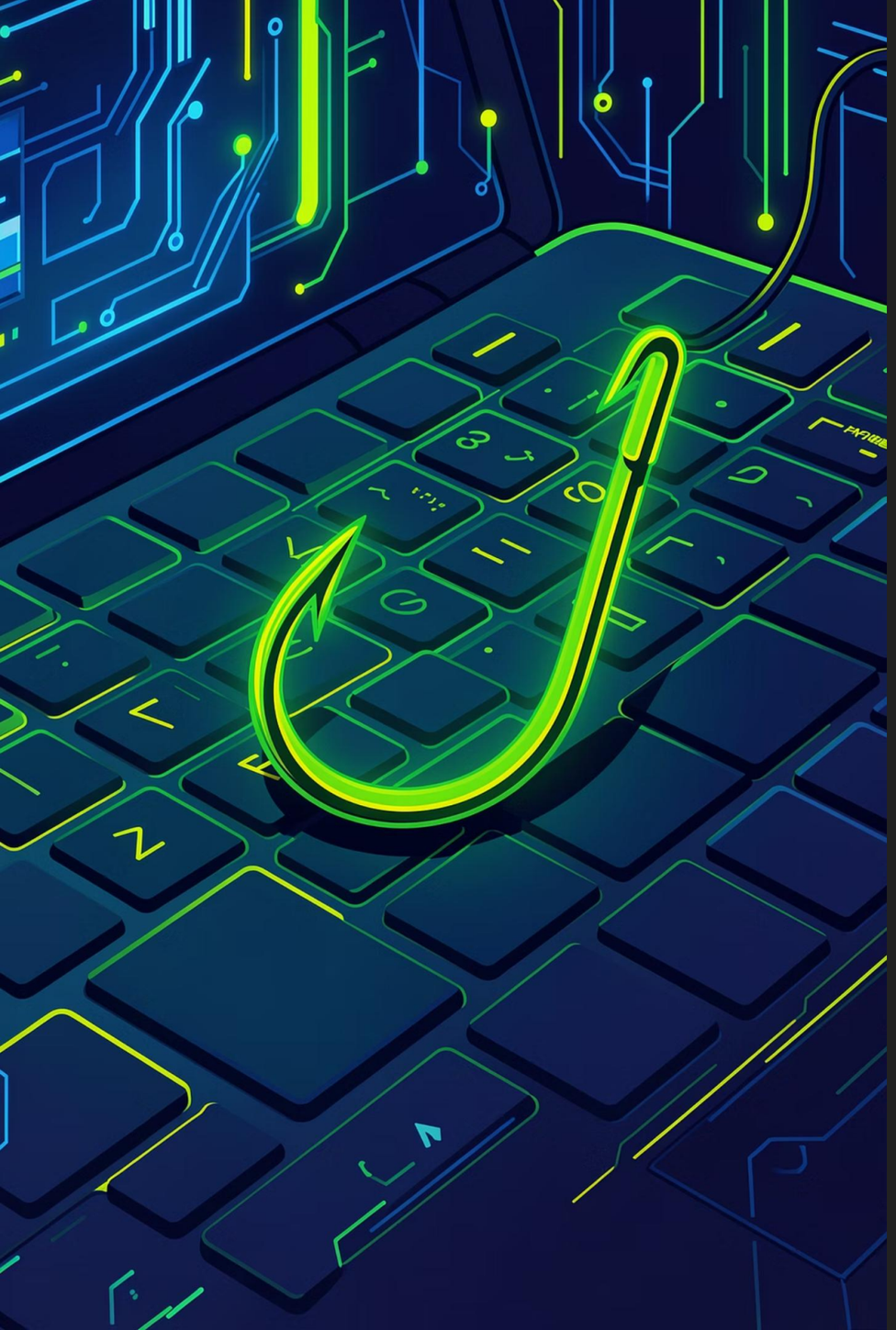


Phishing Awareness Training

How to recognize, avoid, and respond to phishing attacks — a practical guide for cybersecurity interns.

CYBERSECURITY INTERNSHIP PROGRAM

What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of **social engineering attack** where cybercriminals disguise themselves as trustworthy sources — like banks, coworkers, or popular websites — to trick you into revealing sensitive information.

⚠ Phishing is one of the #1 causes of data breaches worldwide. Anyone can be a target.

Goal

Steal passwords, credit card numbers, or personal data

Method

Fake emails, texts, calls, or websites that look real

Weapon

Psychology — urgency, fear, and trust manipulation

Real-Life Example: The Google & Facebook Scam

What Happened?

Between 2013 and 2015, a Lithuanian hacker **posed as a legitimate hardware vendor** and sent fake invoices to Google and Facebook. Both companies wired him over **$100 million** before the fraud was detected.

> Even the world's most sophisticated tech companies can fall for phishing. It proves that **human error** is the biggest vulnerability in any system.

Types of Phishing

Email Phishing

Mass fake emails sent to thousands of people, pretending to be banks or services like PayPal or Netflix.

Spear Phishing

Highly targeted attack using your name, job title, or personal details to seem more believable.

Smishing & Vishing

Phishing via **text message (smishing)** or **phone call (vishing)** — often impersonating the IRS or your bank.

Whaling

Attacks targeting **senior executives** or decision-makers — higher stakes, more personalized.

Signs of a Phishing Attempt

⚠️ Urgent or Threatening Language

"Your account will be suspended in 24 hours!" Pressure tactics are a classic red flag.

🔗 Suspicious Links or Attachments

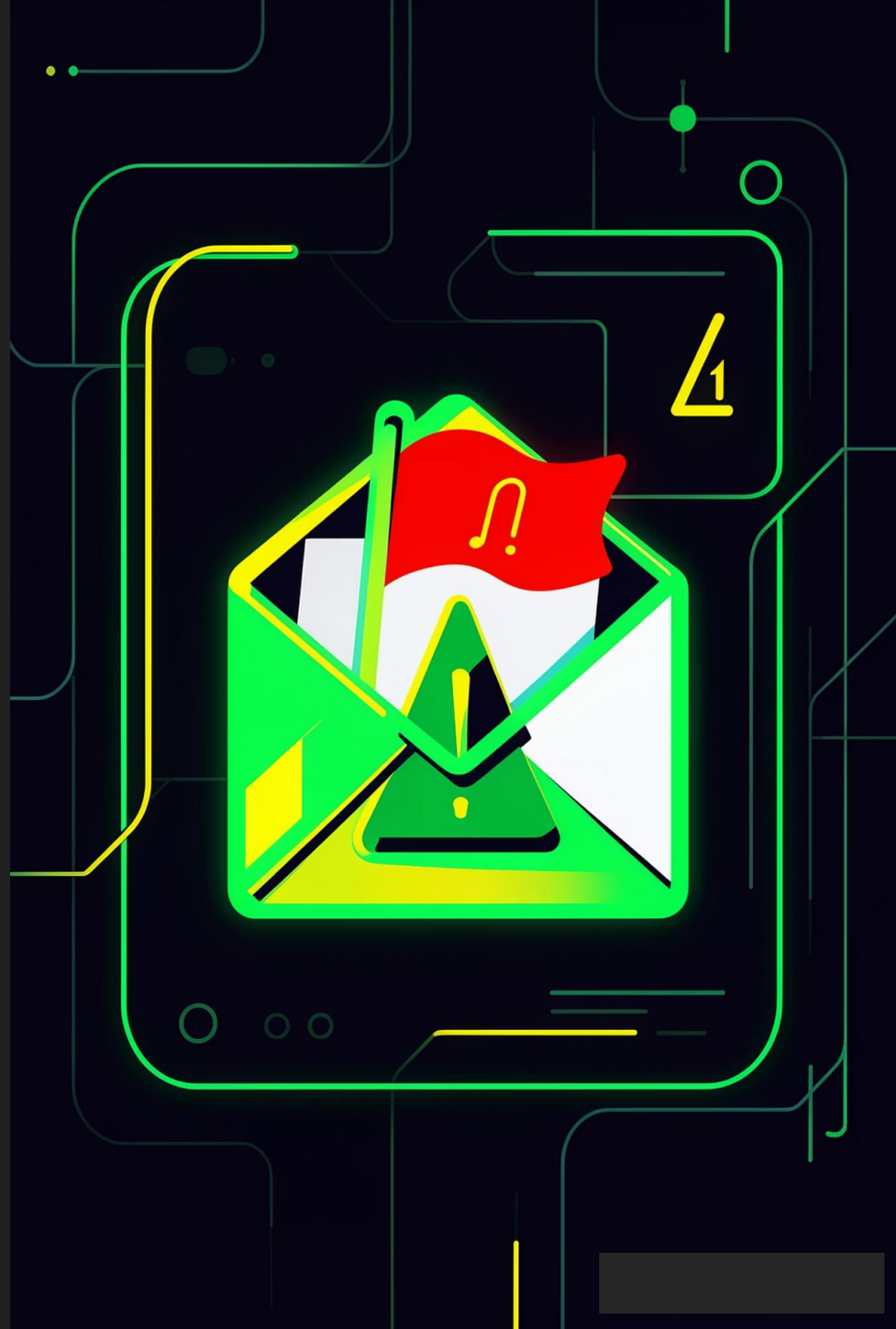
Hover over links before clicking. A URL like `paypa1.com` is NOT PayPal.

✉️ Mismatched Sender Address

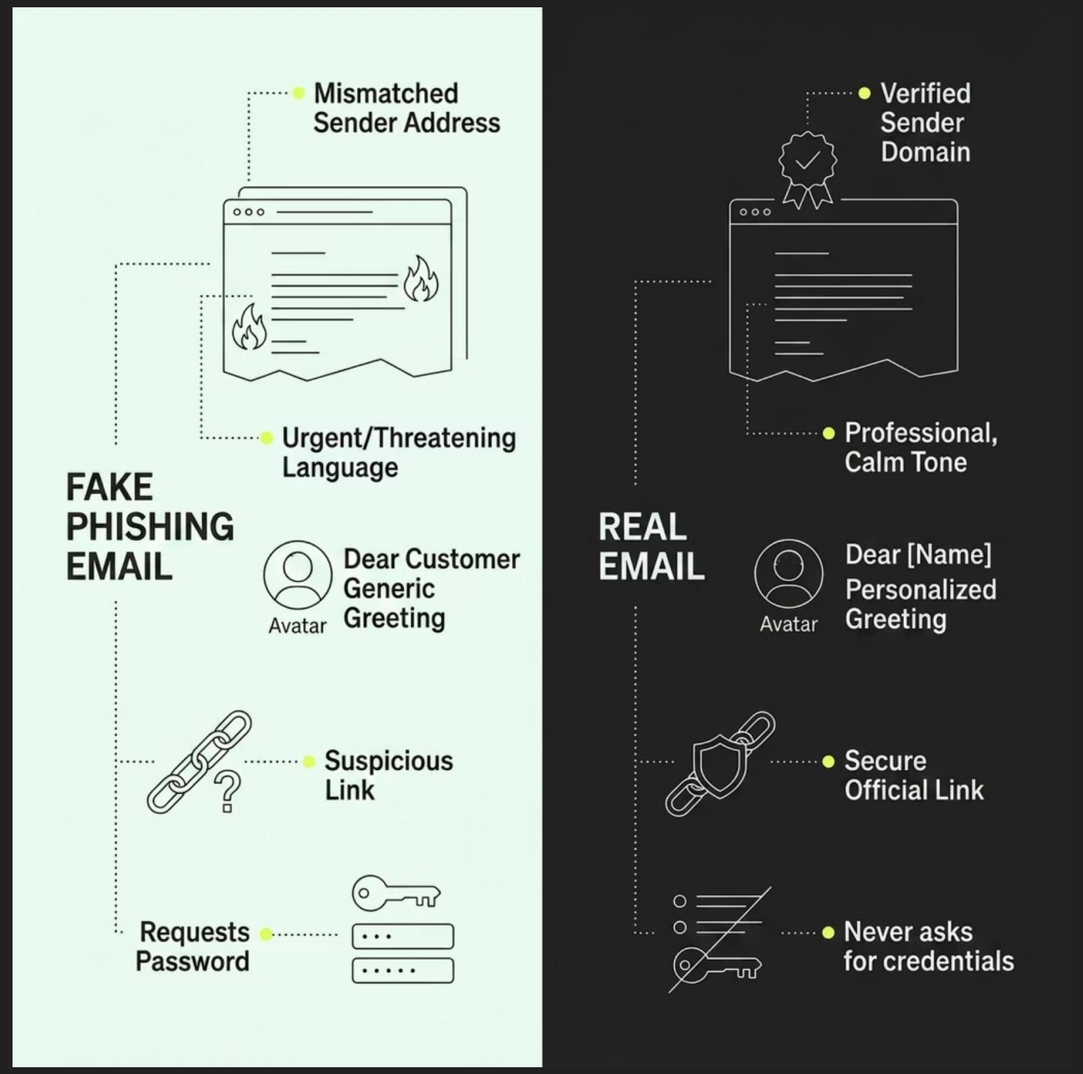
The name says "Apple Support" but the email is from `support@applehelp99.ru`.

🔑 Requests for Sensitive Info

Legitimate companies will **never** ask for your password or SSN via email or text.



Fake vs. Real: Can You Spot the Difference?



How to Verify an Email

- Check the **sender's full email address**, not just the display name
- **Hover (don't click)** over any link to preview the real destination URL
- When in doubt, **go directly** to the company's official website
- Call the sender through an **official, verified phone number** to confirm

How to Stay Safe Online

Enable MFA

Multi-factor authentication adds a second layer of protection even if your password is stolen.

Think Before You Click

Pause and verify before opening any link or attachment — even from someone you know.

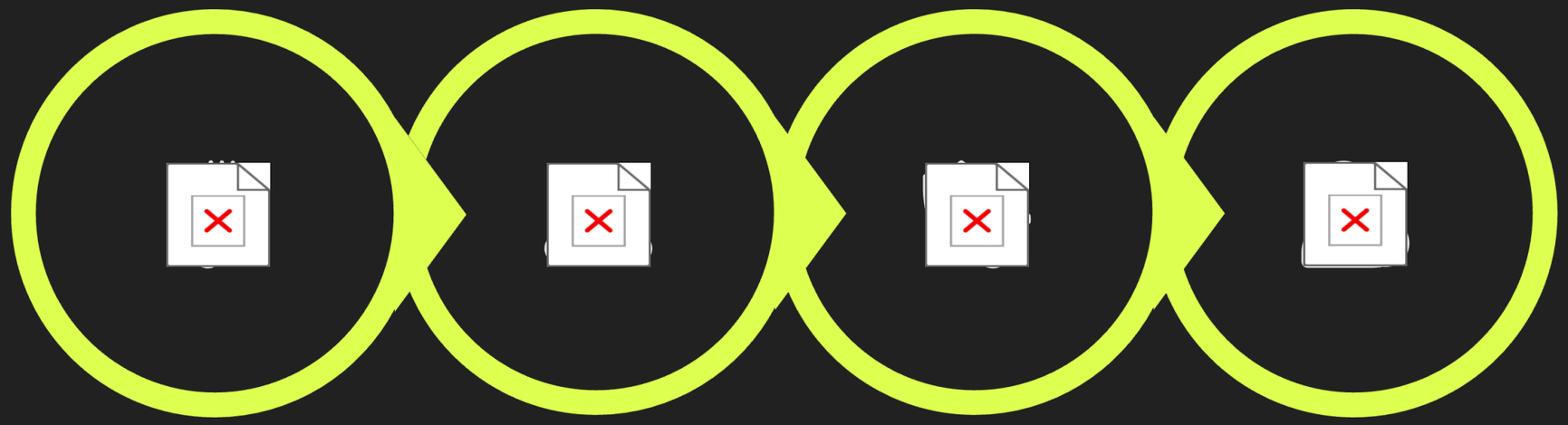
Keep Software Updated

Outdated software has known vulnerabilities. Regular updates patch security holes attackers exploit.

Report Suspicious Emails

Always report phishing attempts to your IT or security team — you could save your whole organization.

What to Do If You've Been Attacked



Disconnect Report Change Monitor

Speed matters. The faster you respond to a phishing incident, the less damage attackers can cause. Never feel embarrassed to report — even security experts get fooled. Reporting quickly protects everyone around you.

Most organizations have a dedicated security team or an "abuse@" email address specifically for reporting phishing. Use it!

Quick Knowledge Check

1

Question 1

You receive an email from `support@paypa1.com` asking you to verify your account immediately. What should you do?

A) Click the link and log in | **B)** Delete and ignore | **C)** Report it to your IT team ✓

2

Question 2

Which type of phishing uses highly personalized details like your name and job title to trick you?

A) Email Phishing | **B)** Spear Phishing ✓ | **C)** Smishing

3

Question 3

A legitimate bank will ask for your password via email if there's a security emergency. True or False?

False ✓ — Legitimate organizations will **never** request credentials over email, ever.

[redacted]

Key Takeaways

Know the Threat

Phishing is everywhere — email, text, phone. Awareness is your first defense.

Spot the Signs

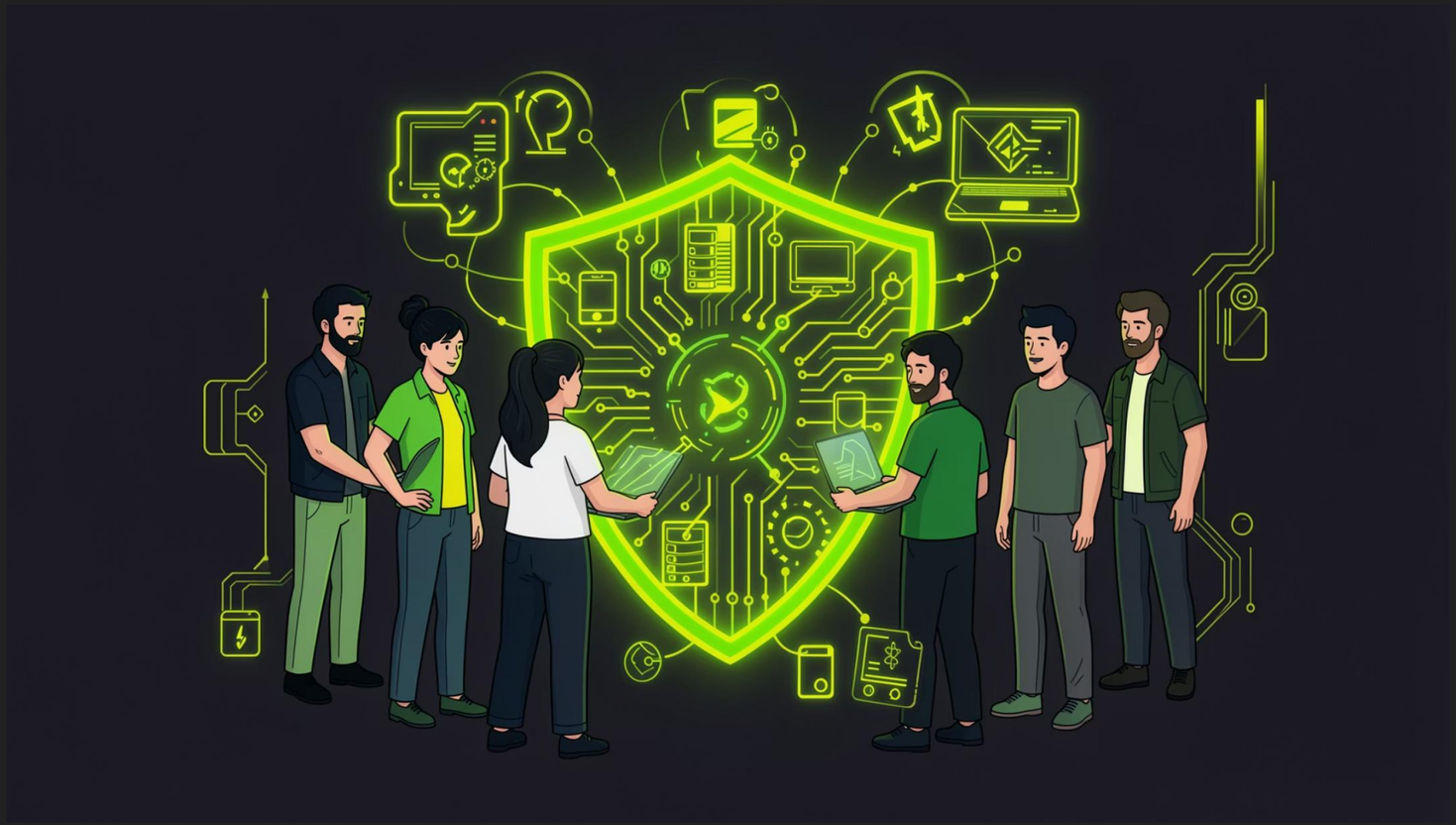
Urgency, suspicious links, and requests for credentials are the biggest red flags.

Stay Protected

Use MFA, verify before you click, and always report suspicious activity.

Respond Fast

If attacked — disconnect, report, change passwords, and monitor your accounts.



> The best defense against phishing isn't technology — it's a **well-trained, alert human being.**